China subsequently agreed on the alignment of the boundary in Sikkim, and China finally acknowledged India's sovereignty over Sikkim in 2003.

The boundary in today's Arunachal Pradesh was formalized at the Simla Conference of 1914 by British India, Tibet and China, creating the so-called McMahon Line. The basis of the McMahon Line was the Himalayan watershed, but there were a few points of difference between the actual watershed and official treaty maps—such as near Tawang (specifically, the Namkachu and Sumdorongchu rivers and the Thagla Ridge between them) and areas such as Longju to the east—all of which were to be flashpoints between India and China in the years to come. However, imperial China did not ratify the Shimla treaty and the People's Republic of China later claimed that the entire McMahon Line was invalid because it was a colonial legacy and Tibet was in any case not an independent party. Tawang in NEFA was of particular strategic value for China. Various other quirks—vague names, poor surveying by the British, even the thickness of the pen nibs used when drawing maps—have contributed to the layers of complications surrounding the boundary situation between India and China. [80]

The poorly demarcated boundary was also linked to the question of Tibet's status. Culturally and historically, China's claim on Tibet is weaker than on Vietnam, Korea, or Mongolia. Chinese military involvement in Tibet prior to the Qing Dynasty was, in fact, very rare. The difference is that unlike the other states, there was never a clear acceptance by China of Tibet's independence and other powers—notably Britain and the United States—were not necessarily dissatisfied with this arrangement. In 1904, Britain recognized Chinese suzerainty—but not sovereignty—over Tibet, mostly to prevent Russian encroachment there. (For its part, Beijing has dismissed suzerainty—which recognizes control of foreign policy but refrains from domestic involvement in a tributary state—as a colonial-era invention and interpreted its rule over Tibet as sovereign.) The United States was also supportive of China's Tibet claims in the early twentieth century out of concern for Japan's rise. [81]